



for the prize after denying the penalty.

This was the second instance this season where East Bengal fans have used tifos to portray referees in a poor light. Even the East Bengal top brass recently organised a media conference to express their displeasure with refereeing decisions, which they claim are denying their team vital points.

The Mohun Bagan SG management has officially complained to the Indian Super League management, requesting an investigation into the controversial issue and appropriate action.

Amitabha Das Sharma

The many firsts at Marina Arena

"Tickets *irukka?* (Do you have tickets?)"

This question was asked of the Diary by multiple children, many clad in Chennaiyin FC jerseys, as he navigated around the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium in the city's Periamet

neighbourhood to attend the match between Chennaiyin and Mohun Bagan. With an air of unshakeable confidence, the Diary replied, "*Venda*" (don't want) to the younglings. In hindsight, he realised his Tamil proficiency had ways to go, but he carried on regardless.

Although not his first time at the JLN media tribune, the Diary was nonetheless greeted by a pleasant breeze wafting in from the Bay of Bengal as he settled into a chair that offered a comprehensive view of the pitch.

The lemon break arrived quickly, prompting him to rush off to appease a rumbling stomach. In the scant 15 minutes available, he devoured as many *parottas* as possible, paired with a delectable chicken curry. A sandy-brown dog even appeared out of nowhere, eyeing the plate, but the canine had to leave disappointed.

Worried that he would miss a pivotal moment in the match after the interval, the Diary hurried back to

Star value: Bollywood actor Abhishek Bachchan, who co-owns Chennaiyin FC, attended his team's match against Mohun Bagan. FSDL

his seat, clutching a bowl of *gajar ka halwa* (carrot pudding), but nothing noteworthy transpired. While monotony reigned on the pitch, the Diary did catch a glimpse of Abhishek Bachchan cheering Chennaiyin on in his *veshti*.

Down in the mixed zone, India international Pritam Kotal threw subtle shade at his former club, Kerala Blasters, while Scotsman Greg Stewart sipped on coconut water as a few reporters questioned him. These scenes did balance out the banal proceedings on the pitch.

While a colleague mentioned that players sipping from coconuts post-match is commonplace, it was one of the many firsts for the Diary at the Marina Arena.

Rajdeep Saha